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Should We Be Playing Kickers More in NFL Showdown?

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Nothing says NFL showdown quite like **Chris Boswell** scoring 26 DraftKings points in an 18-10 win over the Falcons, where the lone offensive highlight was a 41-yard pass, setting up Boswell's third field goal of the first half.

You needed a shower at 11:00 p.m. CT to rinse off the stench of that game, but if you rostered Boswell, you were doing so with a few more dollars in your pocket. That's the question this article will answer: Should we be rostering kickers more in NFL showdown?

Historical ownership pushes back on that assumption: 64.1% of all primetime NFL showdown lineups in the DraftKings flagship contest roster *no* kickers. The position, even in our analysis of them, often gets dismissed as a shrug or the last piece you click in when you've already built a lineup you like. That dismissal may have worked in the past, but it's becoming harder to defend now.

The NFL's kickoff rule was overhauled in 2024 and changed again in 2025, along with a revamp of the K-Ball preparation rules that have resulted in a change to how kickers are producing fantasy points, resulting in more field goal attempts, improved accuracy, expanded range, and better DraftKings scoring on a per-game basis. Have our opponents priced those things in?

We'll use our database of 22.4 million weighted contest entries across nearly 200 primetime NFL showdown slates from 2020-2025 to give us an answer for how the DFS field is handling it, and a play-by-play dataset of the kick detail covering 5,594 field goal attempts and 6,438 extra point attempts from all NFL games since 2021 to answer the real-world impact.

PART 1: What The Contest Database Shows

Pre-2025

Before we figure out if the DFS field has adjusted, we need to establish a baseline of what they’ve done historically to identify how it’s changed and whether it’s changed enough. Given the rule changes before the 2025 season, it makes sense to split our contest database into two cohorts: 2021-24 and 2025.

Lineup	Field Utilization	Top-1% Rate	Top-10% Rate	Win Index
No kicker	64.60%	0.99%	9.86%	0.93x
K in Flex	33.50%	1.23%	10.89%	1.15x
K in CPT	1.90%	0.84%	9.32%	0.78x

Pre-2025, at least one kicker in FLEX lineups accounted for 33.5% of all lineups submitted and finished in the top 1% at a 1.23% clip, finding a top-1% finish at a 1.15x relative rate to their field utilization. No-kicker lineups underperformed slightly (0.93x), and kicker at CPT checked in as the worst of the three constructions with just a 0.78x rate.

2025

The 2025 distribution tells a different story. Across 3.8 million weighted lineups, the same three-way split looks like this:



Lineup	Field Utilization	Top-1% Rate	Top-10% Rate	Win Index
No kicker	60.40%	1.03%	9.89%	0.99x
K in Flex	37.20%	1.06%	10.27%	1.02x
K in CPT	2.40%	1.10%	10.57%	1.05x

K in FLEX jumps from 33.5% to 37.2% in 2025, while no-K lineups fell from 64.6% to 60.5%. A somewhat meaningful discovery by the field was that kickers in FLEX were working, and they adjusted.

PART 2: What the ETR Projection & Ownership Data Shows

Let’s take a more general look at kicker projection, ownership, and DraftKings-point performances from our dataset, which spans 197 separate slates from 2020-2025.

Era	Count	Mean FLEX Own	Median FLEX Own	Fav Kicker Own	Dog Kicker Own	Mean CPT Own	Mean FPTS	Mean Proj	Proj Error
Pre- 2025	445	20.40%	19.40%	22.90%	17.90%	1.00%	8.3	8.14	0.16

2025	96	22.70%	22.30%	24.80%	20.70%	1.20%	8.79	8.57	0.22
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Using the same pre-2025 vs. 2025 split, we can see that the market is moving at the individual player level just as it is in the aggregate construction utilization. Average K FLEX ownership moved from 20.4% to 22.7% in 2025, and the elevated ownership was rewarded with increased production. Scoring improved from 8.3 DraftKings points to 8.8 DraftKings points, slightly outperforming their projection in both eras.

DraftKings Pricing: The Algorithm Caught Up

Before we can compare kickers to their salary-matched peers to determine how they stack up against skill players, it’s worth exploring how kicker pricing itself has evolved through the years.

Season	Median Salary	Mean Salary	Avg FPTS	Avg Proj	Proj Error	FPTS / \$1K	Avg Ownership
2020	\$4,000	\$3,937	7.32	8.31	-1	1.86	17.60%
2021	\$4,000	\$3,915	7.62	8.29	-0.68	1.96	18.60%
2022	\$4,000	\$4,071	8.54	7.92	0.62	2.12	22.90%
2023	\$4,800	\$4,656	8.59	7.98	0.61	1.86	20.30%
2024	\$5,000	\$4,953	9.26	8.23	1.03	1.87	22.30%
2025	\$5,000	\$4,988	8.79	8.57	0.22	1.76	22.70%

Median kicker salary was unchanged for three seasons from 2020 through 2022 despite DraftKings points increasing from 7.32 to 8.54, causing kicker value to peak in 2022. Then in 2023, median kicker salary jumped from \$4,000 to \$4,800, before climbing to \$5,000 last season. For context, every other skill position saw its median salary decrease from 2020 to 2025:

Season	QB	RB	WR	TE	K	DST
2020	\$10,600	\$7,200	\$6,600	\$5,600	\$4,000	\$3,600
2021	\$10,800	\$7,200	\$6,400	\$5,200	\$4,000	\$3,600
2022	\$10,100	\$7,000	\$6,400	\$5,000	\$4,000	\$3,900
2023	\$10,000	\$6,900	\$6,300	\$5,200	\$4,800	\$4,000
2024	\$9,700	\$6,600	\$6,200	\$5,200	\$5,000	\$4,000
2025	\$10,000	\$6,800	\$5,800	\$4,600	\$5,000	\$4,000

QB is down \$600, WR \$800, TE \$1,000, and RB \$400, while kickers are up \$1,000. Part of the argument for kicker FLEX was that they were a more salary-efficient option than their counterparts, but that argument is slightly weaker now than it was in 2020-2022. The position remains the highest-scoring option in its own salary tier, but that tier has since shifted upward as the gap between kickers and skill players has narrowed.

Salary-Matched Scoring Comparison



Position	Count	Median Salary	Avg FPTS	Avg Proj Proj	Proj Error	Avg Ownership
K	541	\$4,400	8.39	8.22	0.17	20.80%
TE	294	\$4,800	7.7	7.44	0.25	22.10%
WR	600	\$4,600	7.18	7.08	0.1	18.50%
D/ST	474	\$4,000	6.61	6.17	0.44	16.20%
RB	245	\$4,600	5.62	6.44	-0.82	15.20%

Cross-positional comparisons get tricky because the salary band on kickers is generally narrower, so we wind up comparing them sometimes to depth receivers, change-of-pace running backs, or TE2-type options when matched for salary. But even with that caveat, we find that kickers are the highest-scoring position in their own salary tier at 8.39 average DraftKings points, outperforming their projection by 0.17 points. RBs in the same salary tier, for example, average 5.62 DraftKings points and underperform their base projection by 0.82 points. On a slate-by-slate basis against salary-matched competition, kickers beat same-priced RBs on 71.4% of slates and same-priced WRs at a 59.3% clip.

PART 3: The Real-Game Data

To this point, we’ve only looked at results from DFS contests, namely primetime showdown slates, where we had kicker salaries, projections, ownership, and DraftKings scores. That misses a large portion of the kicker equation from all other non-primetime games. This section will use the play-by-play kick detail from 2021-25, covering 5,594 field goal attempts and 6,438 extra point attempts across 1,424 games to understand how recent rule changes have impacted what’s actually happening on the field.

Season	FGA/gm	FGM/gm	FG%	Avg Dist	55+ att/gm	55+ FG%	XPA/gm	DK avg	DK med
2021	1.91	1.63	85.30%	38.6	0.094	52.80%	2.34	7.61	7
2022	1.96	1.67	85.40%	39.2	0.142	61.30%	2.22	7.78	7
2023	1.97	1.69	85.80%	39.1	0.139	59.00%	2.2	7.85	7
2024	2.07	1.75	84.20%	39.9	0.167	58.50%	2.32	8.15	8
2025	2.04	1.74	85.60%	40.5	0.209	63.20%	2.36	8.31	8

Field goal volume is on the rise: Field goal attempts per kicker per game rose from 1.91 in 2021 to a peak of 2.07 in 2024 and held steady at 2.04 in 2025, representing an 8% increase over four seasons. The median drive started 75 yards from the kicker’s own end zone in 2021-23 and moved to 70 yards in 2024 and 67 in 2025. The resulting eight yards of improved field position flows directly into more field goal opportunities.

Average attempt distance is growing: Average FG attempt distance increased from 38.6 yards in 2021 to 40.5 yards in 2025. It’s plausible that the K-ball rule change, which allows teams to receive their designated kicking balls at the beginning of the season rather than 90 minutes before kickoff, is leading to increased confidence from both coaching staffs and kickers to attempt longer



field goals. It’s not just the average distance increasing, either. The 55-yard-plus bucket increased from 0.09 attempts per kicker per game in 2021 to 0.21 in 2025, and the 2025 make rate increased to 63.2% from 52.8% in 2021. Kickers are attempting more field goals, more long-range field goals, and making them more often than they used to.

Season	Total Games	10+ pts	15+ pts	20+ pts
2021	561	33.70%	7.00%	0.90%
2022	565	32.70%	6.40%	0.90%
2023	563	32.10%	8.00%	1.20%
2024	567	37.00%	10.10%	2.50%
2025	562	38.40%	10.30%	1.40%

As a result, DraftKings scoring across all games has increased from 7.6 in 2021 to 8.3 in 2025, while the median has improved by a full point. The ceiling performances have followed, as the 15+ DraftKings-point rate jumped from 7.0% in 2021 to 10.3% in 2025.

What the Data Tells Us

Using the data from all three sources — contest entries, ETR projections and ownership, and real-game kick detail — we get a nuanced answer to the question “should we be rostering kickers more?”



Before 2025, the answer was a resounding yes. Lineups that featured a kicker in FLEX posted a 1.15x win index across more than 15 million contest entries. Our opponents simply weren't playing kickers as often as they should.

In 2025, that equation shifted because both the field and DraftKings' pricing algorithm caught up. As kicker in FLEX became more popular (37.2% of all lineups), the median salary increased from \$4,000 to \$5,000, compressing the win index to virtually breakeven, despite kicker performance improving. Playing kickers indiscriminately no longer offers the blanket advantage it once did as salary and ownership discounts have evaporated.

The real-game data still paints a positive forward-looking picture for the position, further complicating things. DraftKings scoring per kicker game is the highest it's ever been, ceiling game frequency has increased since 2021, and the K-ball rules have had a meaningful impact on both long-range FG frequency and success, which means the position is simply better than it was when the showdown format was created.

What I'll be watching for in 2026:

Utilization of favored kicker in 5-1 builds: In 2025, 41.6% of all 5-1 lineups included the favored kicker in FLEX, up from 37.9% prior. The advantage for playing a kicker in 5-1 builds vs. no kicker was virtually indistinguishable in 2025 after being a common fixture in top-1% finishing lineups in previous seasons. If the field's utilization of favored kickers in onslaught builds remains high, it makes sense to look elsewhere this season.

Dome games: Average kicker DraftKings scoring peaked at 9.2 points in dome games last season, compared to 7.9 for outdoor games. Dome kickers score 15+ DraftKings points 12.0% of the time compared to 6.7% for outdoor kickers. This is likely partially priced in by the DFS market, but if kicker ownership is depressed in these environments, I'll be more willing to target them aggressively.

K at CPT: Ugh, I didn't want to have to write this, I promise. However, the changes to kickoffs improving starting field position and the new K-ball era are clearly giving rise to higher kicker ceilings, as noted above. 2.4% of all primetime showdown lineups in 2025 rostered a kicker at CPT, so I'm not looking to pile into **Ka'imi Fairbairn** at 4.9% ownership or **Brandon Aubrey** at 2.8%. But I'm no longer entirely dismissing the position as a legitimate threat to lead the slate in overall scoring.

K in close-spread environments: In games decided by one touchdown or fewer, both kickers average 2.2 field goal attempts and 2.1 extra point attempts per game, with the winner (8.3 DK points) and loser (8.4) posting nearly identical average fantasy scores. If underdog kickers stay lower-owned (18.8%) than favorites (23.4%), as was the case in 2025, there's a window to buy in games that project for a narrow margin of victory.

Chris Boswell, Pittsburgh Steelers, In-Season Package, Showdown



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